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state assembly - Blue wave likely for L.A. County districts

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In 2018, Democrats were able to paint every congressional seat in Orange County blue. Los Angeles County was looking similar. And now that the party holds the supermajority in the California Assembly, it'll be gunning for the GOP's remaining legislative seats in the upcoming election March 3.

Of the 24 Assembly districts within and overlapping L.A. County, only two districts have a Republican sitting in a legislative seat. If the GOP is at all divided on where it stands in the Donald Trump era, it'll need to reconcile to reverse the blue tidal wave of 2018.

Here is a roundup of the 2020 L.A. County Assembly races:

District 36

Incumbent Tom Lackey will try to hold on to his post as one of the only Republican legislators in Los Angeles County. In 2018, he won just by just over 4 percentage points against Democrat Steve Fox, whom he will be facing again this election. Aside from Fox, Lackey faces a fleet of five other Democrats — Johnathon Ervin, Lourdes Everett, Diedra Greenaway and Ollie M. McCaulley, none of whom was endorsed by their party.

District 38

Democrat Christy Smith narrowly snatched the Northern L.A. County/Ventura County District 38 seat from Republican Dante Acosta, flipping the district blue in 2018. In the upcoming election, Smith will run for former area Rep. Katie Hill's seat in Congress, leaving two Republicans and four Democrats to compete for the seat.

The Republican candidates are Suzette Martinez Valladares, a former congressional aide, and Luci Volotzky, a small business owner. The Democratic candidates are Annie Cho, a public relations professional; Kelvin Driscoll, program director with L.A. County Social Services; Brandii Grace, a video game designer; and Dina Cervantes, a small-business owner.

The area has been turning blue in recent years, but Republicans think they still have a shot at winning both the congressional and Assembly seats in the area, which includes Simi Valley and Santa Clarita.

District 39

Luz Rivas, the Democratic incumbent in the San Fernando Valley seat, will meet an old foe as she faces Republican candidate Ricardo Benitez, whom she beat in 2018.

Rivas, an MIT and Harvard graduate, worked as an electrical engineer at Motorola and pioneered nonprofit DIY Girls to help provide mentorship for young girls interested in technology and engineering.

Benitez, a conservative Republican and an immigrant from El Salvador, is a business owner. He was also a 2014 candidate for District 18 of the state Senate.

In 2018, snagged took a wide margin against Benitez, taking almost 78% of the votes.

District 41

Incumbent Chris Holden is a Democrat who has held his seat since 2012. He served on the Pasadena City Council for 15 years and as mayor in 1997.

Holden will go up against Republican Robin Hvidston, executive director of anti-illegal immigration group We the People Rising.

Holden won with 64% of the votes against independent Alan Reynolds in 2018.

District 43

Democrat incumbent Laura Friedman was elected in 2016 and did not face any competitors in 2018. This time, the former Glendale mayor and city councilmember will run against Republican Mike Graves, a business owner and independent Robert Sexton, a producer.

District 44

In 2018, Jacqui Irwin, former Thousand Oaks City council member and mayor, nearly lost to Republican Ronda Baldwin-Kennedy, garnering almost 59% of the votes. On March 3, she will go up against another Republican, Denise Pedrow, a construction coordinator for multifamily housing projects.

District 45

Incumbent Jesse Gabriel, a Democrat attorney who has filed lawsuits against President Donald Trump's administration in connection with the Deferred Action for Childhood Arrivals, was elected in 2018 to represent the district, which includes much of the west San Fernando Valley. Unlike previous years in which past Democratic incumbents have fought to keep the district blue from at least one Republican in the running, Gabriel has no competitors this election.

District 46

In the race for the central and south San Fernando Valley seat, Adrin Nazarian, the Democratic incumbent who has been reelected by a landslide every year since 2012, faces another Democrat, Lanira Murphy, a public educator.

District 48

Democrat incumbent Blanca Rubio, elected in 2016, faces no competitors this election. She was an at-large representative on the Baldwin Park Unified Board of Education until she was elected.

District 49

Competitors are up against a formidable candidate as two Democrats and one Republican seek to take down Democrat Edwin Chau, who was elected in 2012. Chau, a law practitioner and small business owner, served as a board member of the Montebello Unified School District for 12 years and was board president three times. He also served as a judge pro tem for the Los Angeles Superior Court.

Republican Burton Brink, lost to Chau back in 2018, earning just shy of 30% of the votes and will run again this election. Democrats Bryan Mesinas Perez, a teacher, and Priscilla Silva, a transportation project coordinator, are also on the ballot.

District 50

Democratic incumbent Richard Bloom will go up against two other blue candidates, Will Hess and Jim King, on March 3. Bloom has held the position since 2012, representing an area that includes Agoura Hills, Bel Air, Beverly

Hills, Brentwood, Hollywood, Hollywood Hills West and Malibu.

District 51

Democrat Wendy Carillo, a labor activist who was brought to the U.S. from El Salvador as a child, won her Assembly seat two years ago in a special election to represent an areat that includes Eagle Rock and Highland Park, among others. She faces no competitors this time.

District 52

Democratic incumbent Freddie Rodriguez, who has held the seat since 2013, is running against Republican Toni Holle, an account technician against overregulation and for low taxes. Rodriguez served on the Pomona City Council for seven years. The seat includes much of the Inland Valley, including Ontario, Chino and Pomona, among others.

District 53

Miguel Santiago, the Democratic incumbent who has held office since 2014, will be challenged by fellow Democrat Godfrey Santos Plata, an advocate for public educators.

The district encompasses areas including Koreatown, Little Tokyo and Huntington Park.

District 54

Incumbent Sydney Kamlager, a Democrat who was appointed in 2018, was president of the Los Angeles Community College District board of trustees and district director to state Sen. Holly J. Mitchell.

Kamlager is running against two Democrats — Clinton Brown, a real estate developer, and Tracy Bernard Jones, a teacher — and one Republican, Glen Ratcliff. Ratcliff, who adamantly campaigns to reduce taxes and poverty, has run for the same seat in 2018, 2016 and 2014.

District 55

District 55, otherwise known as Richard Nixon’s birthplace, has been a historically Republican region, but as to be expected, Democrats will try to flip this seat blue. GOP incumbent Philip Chen won the seat in 2016 with ease. He is challenged by Democratic Party-endorsed Andrew Rodriguez, a Walnut City Council member.

District 57

This historically blue, working-class and Latino southern San Gabriel Valley district will see two political families go head to head. Incumbent Ian Calderon is not running for reelection, but his storied family legacy precedes him — there has been a Calderon in a legislative seat every year for for decades. His stepmother, Democrat Lisa Calderon, will run in his stead.

Among the seven other Democrats on the ballot is Syliva Rubio, sister to Sen. Susan Rubio and Assemblywoman Blanca Rubio.

The ballot also includes Democrats Josue Alvarado, Primo Castro, Gary Mendez, Dora Sandoval, Vanessa Tyson and Oscar Valladares.

Jessica Martinez, the sole Republican candidate, will try to beat out both families and flip the seat red for the second time as she lost in 2018 with 35% of the vote.

District 58

This largely Latino and suburban area, which includes Bell Gardens, Pico Rivera and Montebello and Commerce, has been blue since the early 1990s. Democratic incumbent Cristina Garcia, who was elected in 2012, likely will keep it that way.

Garcia was one of more than half a dozen California Democratic lawmakers from L.A. County accused of sexual harassment since 2017, when the scandal involving Hollywood mogul Harvey Weinstein drew attention to problems in many industries. In Garcia's case, she lost seats on four committees and faced a rebuke in the Assembly, though an investigation formally cleared her of wrongdoing and she retained her sat. She went on to a lopsided victory. Her challenger is Margaret Villa from the Green Party.

District 59

This urban South Los Angeles district elected Democratic incumbent Reggie Jones-Sawyer in 2012. Jones-Sawyer, a state secretary for the California Democratic Party and president of New Frontier Democratic Club, will meet a formidable challenger, Democrat Efren Martinez, a public policy commissioner.

Republican Marcello Villadea also is running. He is described as an ordinary working-class person.

District 62

The South Bay sees two contenders for the Assembly as Democratic incumbent Autumn Burke, who won by a huge margin in the past three primary elections.

Republican Robert Steele will challenge her. Steele is a business man who works in technology. He has lived in Culver City in 2015.

District 63

Rematch!

This heavily Democratic region — which includes South Gate and a part of Long Beach — will see a tough match between two blue candidates — incumbent Anthony Rendon and Maria Estrada. Rendon barely won with 54% of the votes over Estrada in 2018, and she's back in the race March 3.

District 64

South L.A. and South Bay communities will see a Democrat-vs.-Democrat race. Party-endorsed incumbent Mike Gipson was elected in 2014 and was a council member for the city of Carson for nearly a decade. Fatima Iqbal-Zubair was born in Dubai, United Arab Emirates, and has worked as a private tutor and a public educator.

District 66

In 2018, Democrat Al Muratsuchi flipped this legislative seat blue from previous Republican Assembly member Frank Scotto. The district — which includes Palos Verdes Estates, Redondo Beach and Torrance — encompasses some politically divided territory, with just a few more Dems than GOP members. This time, Muratsuchi will face opponent Arthur Schaper, a far-right Republican, who was not endorsed by his party.

District 70

Democratic incumbent Patrick O' Donnell has owned this Long Beach seat since 2014. He goes up against a lesser-known Republican competitor in a largely Democratic region.

David Thomas, endorsed by the GOP, hasn't run for an election since 2012, where he lost competing for California Assembly District 32.

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